



NOTRE DAME

BRETT CIANCIA @PickSixPreviews

#4

OVERALL



NOTRE DAME				
5-YEAR WIN TREND				
16			(NC) OHIO ST	
15			N. ILLINOIS	
14			(P) PENN ST	
13	(B) OKLA ST	USC	(P) GEORGIA	
12	CINCINNATI	STANFORD	(P) INDIANA	TEXAS A&M
11	STANFORD	MARSHALL	USC	MIAMI
10	GA TECH	OHIO STATE	(B) OREGON ST	STANFORD
9	VIRGINIA	(B) S. CAROLINA	ARMY	SYRACUSE
8	NAVY	BC	VIRGINIA	PITTSBURGH
7	UNC	NAVY	FLORIDA ST	NAVY
6	USC	CLEMSON	NAVY	BC
5	VA TECH	SYRACUSE	GA TECH	USC
4	WISCONSIN	UNLV	STANFORD	NC STATE
3	PURDUE	BYU	LOUISVILLE	BOISE ST
2	TOLEDO	UNC	MIAMI OH	ARKANSAS
1	FLORIDA ST	CALIFORNIA	TENN ST (FCS)	PURDUE
			TEXAS A&M	
	2021	2022	2023	2024
	KELLY		MARCUS FREEMAN	

NOTRE DAME					
2025 RESULTS		Yard +/-	TO +/-	GRADE	
MIAMI	L 24-27	-25	-2	48.4	
TEXAS A&M	L 40-41	-59	0	52.9	
PURDUE	W 56-30	156	1	77.4	
ARKANSAS	W 56-13	276	2	103.2	
BOISE ST	W 28-7	74	4	78.9	
NC ST	W 36-7	252	1	113.0	
USC	W 34-24	46	2	86.0	
BOSTON COLL.	W 25-10	177	2	72.3	
NAVY	W 49-10	274	0	99.9	
PITTSBURGH	W 37-15	168	-1	98.3	
SYRACUSE	W 70-7	189	3	88.9	
STANFORD	W 49-20	212	1	85.3	
OVERALL: 4th / 68				83.7	

NOTRE DAME	UNIT RANKS
2026 NATIONAL TOP 15	
QUARTERBACK	4
RUNNING BACKS	
RECEIVERS & TE	
OFFENSIVE LINE	1
DEFENSIVE LINE	3
LINEBACKERS	4
DEFENSIVE BACKS	4

NOTRE DAME	RANK
Scoring Offense	42 ppg 2
Points per Play	0.67 1
Total Offense	459 ypg 12
Yards per Play	7.3 2
Rushing Offense	203 ypg 17
Yards per Carry	5.7 3
O-Line Run Push	4.5 31
Explosive Rush	8.6 2
Passing Offense	255 ypg 37
Yards / Attempt	9.5 2
QB Rating	169 4
TD / INT Ratio	4.2 10
Sacks / Attempt	4% 12
Explosive Pass	10.7 4
Return. Production	67% 19
Returning Snaps	8,933 75
27.8 SECONDS/PLAY #52 of 68 P4	
DENBROCK (2025 ND)	

Fresh off a national title appearance, Notre Dame lost a physical battle at Miami, then lost again in a wild shootout against Texas A&M thanks in part to a botched extra point hold. 0-2 by a combined four points.

The defense rounded into form, new starting quarterback CJ Carr was extremely efficient, and they leaned on their best feature: a running back pair of eventual first-round picks.

Jeremiah Love was a weekly highlight reel, like his 94-yarder to seal the Boston College game, or his video-game spin move against Pittsburgh, and he ran all the way to the Heisman ceremony. His co-star Jadarian Price took back a kickoff 100 yards for a touchdown to help seal the USC win.

After the 0-2 start, Notre Dame dominated the remainder of their schedule. They won their final ten games, all by double-digits, with an average margin of 30 points/game and +190 yardage/game.

The College Football Playoff committee placed Notre Dame at #11, but due to their bylaw granting auto-bids to the best five conference winners (two non-AQ champs due to five-loss Duke), the Irish missed the bracket by one spot.

Athletic director Pete Bevacqua went on a 48-hour tirade across multiple channels and shows. "There is no explanation that could possibly be given to explain the outcome."

Here's an explanation: Notre Dame played two Playoff teams and lost both times. The final spot came down to 10-2 Miami and 10-2 Notre Dame. Miami won when they played each other.

Notre Dame then opted out of bowl season altogether. Iowa State and Kansas State opted out of bowl seasons due to coach transitions that sent 40+ players into the portal. Not the case here.

Separating "deserving resume" from "power ratings," there is no doubting that Notre Dame was Playoff-caliber in the latter. My opponent-adjusted Game Grader placed Notre Dame #4.

OFFENSE

Love and Price ended up as Notre Dame's second 2,000-yard pair of backs since the 1960s joining Jerome Bettis and Reggie Brooks (1992). Love earned unanimous All-America honors, Price got honors as a kick returner, and both were drafted in the first round.

They were the engine of one of the nation's best offenses of 2025. Notre Dame ranked in the top five in scoring with 42 points/game, yards/carry (5.7), QB Rating, and both explosive rushing and passing.

Carr turned in a stellar first year as the starter, ranked #6 in QB Rating, #3 in yards/attempt, and earned Freshman All-America honors. He's got a strong deep ball, nice touch on sideline throws, and quickly took control of the offense as the season went on. When needed, he can tuck the ball and fall forward for key yardage.

Love and Price will be missed as program legends. Aneayas Williams is the new lead back, and had a role in the 2024 playoff run with six touches/game and a high 7.6 per/carry career average.

The offensive line was a strength as usual here, ranking #31 in OL Run Push and #12 in pass protection. Billy Schrauth was drafted and Aamil Wagner graduated, but the other three starters are back. The staff is shifting around their roles, but Anthonie Knapp is a legit All-America contender at guard, Ashton Craig is recovering from an injury at center, and 6'7 Guerby Lambert shifted to tackle. They hope to get injured Charles Jagusah back healthy in time for the season, but if not, Sullivan Absher has plenty of experience. The newcomer is redshirt freshman, former five-star Will Black who won the starting job at left tackle. This should be another elite unit for ace offensive line coach Joe Rudolph.

From spring practice reports, it appears to be an athletic, agile line that may run more outside zone than last year.

One of the most dominant streaks in college football survived another year. Every Notre Dame starting tight end since 2005 was eventually drafted and Eli Raridon continued the lineage. Raridon ranked in the Top 15 of Power 4 with 482 receiving yards, but the 2026 pair -- Cooper Flanagan and James Flanigan -- are stronger in run blocking. Notre Dame signed the #1 tight end recruit this cycle in five-star Ian Premer (Great Bend, KS).

NOTRE DAME										
OFFENSE & DEFENSE, vs. OPPONENT AVERAGE (RANK / 68)										
O	4	10	6	34	25	21	16	30	12	28
F										10th
F	MIKE DENBROCK	PARKER	TOMMY REES	CHIP LONG	SANFORD					
	2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016
D	ASH	AL GOLDEN	FREEMAN	CLARK LEA	ELKO	VanGORDER				
E	6	4	6	19	18	15	8	12	11	28
F										6th

NOTRE DAME		RANK	
Scoring Defense	17.6 ppg	11	
Points per Play	0.26	8	
Total Defense	314 ypg	22	
Yards per Play	4.6	9	
3rd Down Conv%	35%	35	
Rushing Defense	100 ypg	11	
Yards per Carry	3.0	11	
Negative Play %	8%	57	
Explosive Rush	4.4	14	
Passing Defense	213 ypg	56	
Yards / Attempt	6.2	20	
QB Rating	109	9	
Completion %	55.7%	15	
Explosive Pass	4.9	36	
Return. Production	77%	2	
Returning Snaps	13,880	18	

NOTRE DAME		RANK / 68	
Opponent-Adjusted, Per-Play			
Offense Overall		4	
Rushing Offense	1.6	3	
Passing Offense	32.2	6	
Defense Overall		6	
Rushing Defense	1.3	8	
Passing Defense	34.2	3	

spot. All three are former Top200 prospects: Dallas Golden, Mark Zackery, and Jayden Sanders (Michigan).

Last year they had to replace All-American Xavier Watts and the secondary took a few games to step up. Redshirt freshman Tae Johnson took the starting job from Jalen Stroman. Johnson and Adon Shuler (27 career starts) are both back, plus Luke Talich is solid in sub-packages like red zone or two-minute drill.

OUTLOOK

After missing the bracket by one spot, Notre Dame has a chance for redemption in 2026. They get virtually the same team back – minus their first-round running backs – and even get a rematch shot at Miami.

This is definitely a top five defense in America, the offensive line is elite again, and Freeman continues to upgrade the program's talent level. Oh, and they have a legit Heisman contender under center in CJ Carr.

The schedule is favorable as they draw only three of my Top 25 teams (Miami, SMU, and @ BYU), plus the bottom four ACC teams, and two of the bottom three from the Big Ten. Notre Dame will return to the Playoff as serious National Title contenders.

Notre Dame loses their reliable slot receiver Will Pauling and 6'4 big-frame Malachi Fields but receiving leader Jordan Faison is back. Faison had a breakthrough 2025 and quit lacrosse to focus fully on his final season. The staff needed to pull in some transfers here, and there is no better spot than Brian Hartline's NFL conveyor belt in Columbus. Notre Dame signed two Ohio State receivers, Mylan Graham and Quincy Porter, and both are former five-star recruits who were stuck in a crowded room. Graham will start in the slot, Porter fills in for Fields' role, and Jaden Greathouse is finally healthy.

DEFENSE

Chris Ash was catching some heat in September after the 0-2 start, and another defensive breakdown against lowly Purdue. But then his defense rounded into form and ended up as one of the most dominant units nationally. Notre Dame finished #6 overall in my opponent-adjusted metric -- #3 passing, #8 rushing – and was elite in every area.

Ash is just getting started, too. 10 starters returned, plus *five* four-star transfers pack the two-deep.

Notre Dame was stout at the point of attack, and Jason Onye and Elijah Hughes return from their five-man tackle rotation. The staff signed All-ACC Francis Brewu (Pittsburgh) and Tionne Gray (Oregon) who were both ranked as top five transfer defensive tackles. Both starting ends return with future NFL-er Boubacar Traore and former five-star Bryce Young. Another former five-star Keon Keeley (Alabama) transferred in.

The full four-man linebacker core returns and all four placed within the team's top six in tackles-for-loss. Drayk Bowen was named a team captain, Kyngstonn Viliamu-Asa has high NFL grades, while Jaiden Ausberry and Jaylen Sneed are solid traditional inside backers.

Leonard Moore earned unanimous All-America honors and is arguably the best overall player in the nation. He returns as a lockdown corner, his co-starter Christian Gray shifted over to the nickel spot, while a new trio battles of the second corner

NOTRE DAME	
2026 SCHEDULE	
S. 6	*WISCONSIN (GB)
S. 12	RICE
S. 19	MICHIGAN ST
S. 26	@ Purdue
O. 3	@ UNC
O. 10	STANFORD
O. 17	@ BYU
O. 24	--- BYE ---
O. 31	*NAVY (BOSTON)
N. 7	MIAMI
N. 14	BOSTON COLL.
N. 21	SMU
N. 28	@ Syracuse

NOTRE DAME		RANK / 68	
All-Time Wins	972	4	
All-Time Win %	0.732	3	
Wins (Last 100)	760	6	
Wins (Last 50)	401	16	
Wins (Last 25)	196	23	
Wins (Last 10)	101	5	
Wins (Last 5)	54	6	
Game Grader (10 yr)	71.2	5	
Game Grader (5 yr)	73.3	5	
Game Grader (3 yr)	79.5	3	
Draft Picks s' 2000	124	11	
Draft Picks s' 2010	82	11	
Player Development: Recruit Rank ('19-'22) vs. Draft ('23-'26)		36	
Win Conversion: Recruit Rank ('17-'25) vs. Wins ('21-'25)		31	

NOTRE DAME		GAME GRADER (RANK / 68)									
2025	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018	2017	2016	10-YEAR	
83.7 (4)	77.2 (5)	77.6 (6)	60.2 (22)	67.5 (10)	69.4 (14)	75 (9)	74.6 (7)	75.3 (10)	51.4 (33)	71.2 (5)	

